
Pietro Mascagni

1863–1945, ITALIAN

Chiefly remembered as the composer of the one-act opera *Cavalleria rusticana*, Mascagni was born in Livorno, Tuscany, the son of a baker. Choosing a musical career against his family's wishes, he began composing in his teenage years. Admitted to the Milan Conservatory in 1882, he left without completing his course, working as conductor with a touring opera company. In 1888, he won a prestigious competition for the score of *Cavalleria rusticana*. Premiered in 1890, the opera was a sensational hit, establishing the earthy, melodramatic Italian operatic style known as *verismo*. Raised to fame, Mascagni went on to write 14 more operas. Most were high-profile cultural events—notably *Parisina*, with a libretto by poet Gabriele D'Annunzio, premiered at La Scala in 1913—but none matched the success of his first. Mascagni also had a prominent career as a conductor. His last opera, *Nerone* (1935), was a tribute to Mussolini's Fascist regime.

KEY WORKS: *Cavalleria rusticana* (opera), 1890; *L'amico Fritz* (opera), 1891; *Iris* (opera), 1898; *Isabeau* (opera), 1911